

LENG-104 ESL1: Course Syllabus

English as a Second Language, Level 1 (A1/A2)

Class Meetings

Tuesdays	9:00am to 10:50am · 150 Massachusetts Avenue, Room A75
Thursdays	10:00am to 10:50am · 7 Haviland Street, Room 306
Term	Tuesday May 26 through Friday August 14, 2026 · 12-week compressed format

Instructor

Name	Prof. Kramer Gibson
Email	ggibson1@berklee.edu
Office	7 Haviland Street, Room 326
Office hours	Tuesdays 11:00am to 1:00pm at 7 Haviland Street Room 326, walk-in, and also by appointment
Course site	kramermusician.github.io/esl1-summer-2026

Course Description

LENG-104 ESL1 is the entry-level English course for non-native speakers at Berklee. The course builds listening, speaking, reading, and writing in English at the A1 to A2 level. Students develop the language foundation they need for college coursework while working with authentic materials including songs, podcasts, short articles, and conversations in and around Boston. The course pairs classroom instruction with weekly one-on-one tutoring.

Welcome to ESL1

ESL1 is the first English language course at Berklee. We will spend 12 weeks together building the foundation you need to write, speak, listen, and read in English at the college level. The class is small and the room is friendly. Everyone is here to grow.

Most of our work happens together in class, on paper, in conversation. Canvas is where you submit a few things and where I track attendance. Our public course site at kramermusician.github.io/esl1-summer-2026 is where each week's readings and worksheets live.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- Speak about themselves, their experiences, and their opinions in English at the A2 level, using simple past, present, and present perfect tenses.
- Read short authentic English texts (articles, song lyrics, podcast transcripts) and respond using appropriate vocabulary and grammar.
- Write short, organized paragraphs in English that show clear control of simple past, present perfect, and basic passive voice.
- Listen to authentic spoken English (songs, podcasts, classroom conversation) and identify main ideas and key details.
- Build and maintain an active English vocabulary using independent study tools (Anki flashcards, tutoring sessions, in-class routines).

Course Materials

All readings, worksheets, and handouts are free and live on the public course site at kramermusician.github.io/esl1-summer-2026. You will also need:

- A notebook (the MUJI Recycled Paper Notebook 0.3 inch lined B5, available on Newbury Street for about \$2.40, is the one I recommend).
- A pencil and a colored pen for corrections.
- Anki (free flashcard app) on your phone or computer.
- Headphones for in-class listening activities.

Requirements, Expectations, and Grading

Course Requirements

To complete this course successfully, students are expected to:

- Attend every scheduled class meeting on time.
- Attend one hour of one-on-one tutoring each week (required, scheduled with your tutor).
- Complete in-class worksheets, packets, and the weekly News! Vocabulary! routine.
- Submit five tutoring reflection audio recordings to Canvas (Weeks 3, 5, 7, 9, 11).
- Complete the Hidden Theme Podcast project (launches Week 8, due Week 10).
- Take grammar and vocabulary quizzes as scheduled.
- Complete the final writing assessment (Week 11) and the final speaking assessment (Week 12).

Classroom Expectations

This room belongs to all of us. A few simple expectations keep it working well:

- Try English first. If you cannot find the word, your first language is welcome as a bridge.
- Listen respectfully to your classmates. Everyone's English is growing at a different pace, and everyone deserves a kind room to grow in.
- Ask questions any time. Ask in English if you can, or in your first language if you cannot. Never stay confused in silence.
- If you need help, need to step out, or are having a hard day, tell me. I would rather know than not know.
- Bring your notebook and a pencil to every class. We write by hand often.

Grade Determination

Your grade is built from five categories. The biggest share rewards showing up and trying. Speaking matters more than writing at this level, because that is where most of your growth will happen.

Category	Weight	What this includes
Attendance	10%	Coming to class on time. See the Attendance policy on the next page for the details.
Participation	20%	Joining the conversation, sing-alongs, in-class activities, asking and answering questions in English
In-Class Completion	25%	Worksheets, field activities, packets, News! Vocabulary! routine, Diplomatic Intervention message
Quizzes	20%	Grammar and vocabulary quizzes through the semester
Speaking Assessments	15%	Intro voice message, weekly Tutoring Reflections, mid-semester check-in, final speaking
Writing Assessments	10%	Final writing assessment in Week 11

Grading Scale

A	93-100%	A-	90-92%	B+	87-89%	B	83-86%
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B-	80-82%	C+	77-79%	C	73-76%	Below C	under 73%
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Grading Criteria

The scale above is the math. The descriptions below are how I read your overall work in this course. Specific assignments have their own rubrics where it matters.

A (93-100). Strong growth across speaking, writing, reading, and listening. Work is complete and on time. Speaks English in class often and tries new words and grammar without being asked. Tutoring reflections show real reflection, not just summary.

A- (90-92). Strong growth and consistent effort. Work is mostly complete and on time. Speaks English in class often, with small areas to polish.

B+ (87-89). Solid growth. Most work complete and on time. Speaks English in class with regularity. Some areas for more careful work.

B (83-86). Clear progress. Work is mostly complete. Speaks English often enough in class. Room to push further.

B- (80-82). Basic progress. Work is mostly there but with gaps. Speaks English when prompted. Room for more independence.

C+ (77-79). Some progress. Several gaps in completed work. Speaks English sometimes. Needs to ask for help more often.

C (73-76). Minimal progress. Many gaps. Rarely speaks English in class.

C- to D (60-72). Significant gaps in growth, attendance, or completed work. The course foundation is not yet in place. Outside support and likely a second pass at the level would help.

F (0-59). Does not show engagement with the course. Work is missing or incomplete.

W / S / U. Withdraw / Satisfactory / Unsatisfactory.

Weekly Tutoring (Required)

Every student in a Berklee ESL course meets with a tutor for one hour each week. This is a required part of the program. You will receive more information about your tutoring schedule and your assigned tutor from me in the first week of class.

Five times during the semester (Weeks 3, 5, 7, 9, and 11) you will record a short audio reflection at the end of your tutoring session and submit it to Canvas. That recording is your Tutoring Reflection, and it lives in the Speaking part of your grade.



Course Policies

Attendance

Attendance is the foundation of this course. Coming to class on time, every class, is the single biggest thing you can do to grow in English this summer. The attendance rule is simple and the same for everyone:

- You may miss up to 3 classes with no penalty, for any reason. You do not need to tell me why.
- If you miss 4 or 5 classes, you earn a 0 for the Attendance category. That is 10% of your final grade. You can still pass the course.
- If you miss 6 or more classes, you will fail the course.
- 2 tardies count as 1 absence. Come to class on time.
- Apart from extreme situations, there are no excused absences. Use your three free absences wisely.
- If you must miss a class, email me before the class meets.

Berklee policy: "Attendance is required in all classes, private lessons, instrumental labs, and ensembles, beginning with the first scheduled meeting. Absences must be addressed directly with the course instructor to determine impact on student progress and/or overall grade. Classes are scheduled to start promptly on the hour and end at ten minutes before the hour. Late arrival is both unprofessional and disruptive. Berklee recognizes that students will be presented with professional opportunities such as job interviews, auditions, and exceptional performance opportunities. Students are not excused from course assignments or deadlines and are required to discuss the ramifications of any related absences with their course instructors in advance."

Late Work

Late work loses 5% per day and closes after 7 days. If you need an extension, ask before the deadline. I am almost always willing to work with you when you communicate early.

Course-Specific Policies

Phones and laptops

Be respectful about tech use. Sometimes we use phones and laptops in class. During a discussion, partner work, or writing time, I may ask you to put these things away. When I ask, please do.

Food and drink

Drinks are fine any time. Food is fine too, as long as it is quiet and you are willing to share, or at least to not disturb your neighbors.

Notebook

Bring your notebook and a pencil to every class. We write by hand often, and your notebook is part of how you learn.

Academic Honesty

Write in your own English. You may use your first language to think, plan, and brainstorm. You may use a dictionary. You are here to grow your English, so the work you turn in needs to be your work, even when it is imperfect. Imperfect English from you teaches me where to help. Perfect English from a machine teaches me nothing.

Berklee policy: "Berklee insists on academic honesty. Unless the assignment explicitly is a group project, all of the work in this class must be your own. The source of all information in any written assignment must be cited properly, whether it is a

quotation, paraphrase, summary, idea, concept, statistic, picture, or anything else you get from any source other than your own immediate knowledge, including the Internet. Plagiarism, not giving proper credit to a source and thereby passing off someone else's material or idea as your own, is a type of intellectual theft and deceit and cannot be tolerated in an academic setting. Plagiarism may result in a failing grade for the assignment or course, and possible dismissal from the College."

Resources on plagiarism and citation: owl.purdue.edu · writing.wisc.edu/handbook · nmsu.libguides.com/citingyoursources

AI Use

You can use AI tools in this class. The rule is transparency. If you use an AI tool on any part of your work, tell me which tool you used and how you used it. Cite your sources, including AI sources. Be ready to explain all aspects of your submitted work in conversation with me. If you cannot explain a sentence you turned in, that sentence is not really yours yet, and we both need to know that.

Berklee policy: "Policies around the use and incorporation of artificial intelligence (AI) will vary, and students should refer to syllabi and/or their course instructors for policies specific to their class or to specific assignments. In the absence of a policy or direction from the instructor specifically permitting the use of AI, using AI to substantially complete coursework, either directly or with modification, and presenting it as original work constitutes a violation of academic integrity and will be treated analogously as receiving help from another person. Students with questions about the use of AI or academic integrity should check with their instructor before submitting work."

Important Dates and 12-Week Schedule

Important Dates

- **Add/drop period:** May 26 to June 2, 2026.
- **Last day to withdraw with a W grade:** June 12, 2026.
- **Final exam and ratings audition week:** Monday August 10 to Friday August 14, 2026.
- **Hidden Theme Podcast project due:** Week 10 (week of July 27).
- **Final writing assessment:** Week 11 (week of August 3).
- **Final speaking assessment:** Week 12 (week of August 10).
- **No-class days on Tue/Thu:** none this term. Juneteenth (June 19) falls on a Friday and Independence Day (July 4) falls on a Saturday in 2026, so neither affects our schedule.

12-Week Schedule

Summer 2026 runs on a 12-week compressed format. The schedule below shows the big shape of the course. Specific assignments and due dates live in Canvas and on the course site.

Week	Dates	Focus
1	May 26 - May 30	Welcome to class. Grammar pre-test (no points). Introduce yourself voice message.
2	Jun 1 - Jun 6	Strategies for college English. Past tense. A walk along the Charles.
3	Jun 8 - Jun 13	Singing and listening. Creep (Radiohead). Tutoring reflection #1 due.
4	Jun 15 - Jun 20	Singing and listening. Spectre (Radiohead). Two Countries narrative essay (in-class, no points).
5	Jun 22 - Jun 27	Tech reading + passive voice. WhatsApp and Meta packet. Tutoring reflection #2 due.
6	Jun 29 - Jul 4	Grammar: simple past vs. present perfect.
7	Jul 6 - Jul 11	Grammar quiz. Tutoring reflection #3 due.
8	Jul 13 - Jul 18	Singing: This Feeling (Alabama Shakes). Hidden Theme Podcast project launches.
9	Jul 20 - Jul 25	Podcast planning + vocabulary check. Tutoring reflection #4 due.
10	Jul 27 - Aug 1	Podcast due. Diplomatic Intervention message (writing).
11	Aug 3 - Aug 8	Final writing assessment. Review. Tutoring reflection #5 due.
12	Aug 10 - Aug 14	Final exam / ratings audition week. Final speaking assessment. Course wrap.

All schedule information is subject to change with ample notice at the discretion of the professor.

Department and College-Wide Information

Department Contact Information

Liberal Arts and Sciences Department

Dr. Marcela Castillo Rama, Chair · mcastillorama@berklee.edu · 617-747-6752 · 7 Haviland, Room 336

Dr. Jennifer Beauregard, Assistant Chair · jbeauregard@berklee.edu · 617-747-8062 · 7 Haviland, Room 300

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Liberal Arts and Sciences Department Equity Mission Statement

The Liberal Arts and Sciences Department at Berklee strives to provide a supportive environment for all students, regardless of sex, gender identity, sexual identity and orientation, health, ability, social class, and racial, ethnic, religious, national, and personal backgrounds. Our strength is in our differences, and a diverse community promotes equity through the support of and respect for people with a broad range of backgrounds and experiences. We welcome the opportunities to work with and learn from each other.

For information on Berklee's Equity policy: www.berklee.edu/equity

Title IX

Berklee is a diverse community composed of individuals with different life experiences, viewpoints, belief systems, and identities. A welcoming and inclusive culture is essential to maintaining the college's role as a leader in music education. The Equity Policy and Process prohibits and addresses sexual misconduct, as well as other forms of discrimination and/or harassment based on legally protected characteristics and provisions covered under Title IX of federal law. If you have concerns about a possible violation of the college's Equity Policy, please contact equity@berklee.edu. For more information, visit www.berklee.edu/equity.

FERPA

In compliance with the federal Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act of 1974 (FERPA), Berklee is prohibited from providing certain information from your education records to a third party. The law also restricts Berklee from providing this information to your parents, spouse, or financial sponsor. In compliance with this act, faculty members cannot be in contact with students' parents or guardians without prior authorization. In the event that your parent or guardian reaches out to your professor, you will be notified via email and asked to reply to grant this authorization. Visit Berklee's page on Student Privacy Rights under FERPA for more information.

Support Services

The Center for Liberal Arts and Sciences Tutoring (CLAST) offers various tutoring services to the Berklee community. Located at 7 Haviland Street, Room 110, CLAST falls under the auspices of the Liberal Arts and Sciences Department in the Professional Education Division. For more information, please visit www.berklee.edu/liberal-arts-tutoring.

Additional Student Services

- **Counseling Services** · 161 Mass. Ave, 4th floor · 617-747-2310 · www.berklee.edu/counseling
- **One Stop Student Services** (registration, billing, financial aid) · 921 Boylston St., 1st floor, suite 100 · 617-747-6777 · www.berklee.edu/one-stop
- **Student Success Advising** (schedules, withdrawals, academic progress) · 939 Boylston Street, 3rd floor · 617-747-6535 · college.berklee.edu/student-success-advising/appointments
- **Accessibility Resources** · 939 Boylston Street, 2nd floor · 617-747-2387 · www.berklee.edu/accessibility-resources/appointments
- **Stan Getz Library and Media Center** · 150 Mass. Ave · library.berklee.edu

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